

FEUDALISM



IN PARTS OF MEDIEVAL ASIA and Europe, a system arose for organizing society known as feudalism. In the feudal system, the king gave land to powerful barons, who then gave land and protection to lesser lords, and so on through to the peasants. Each level was then expected to fight to protect its overlords whenever needed. European feudalism started in the late 9th century, and spread all over the continent. Outside Europe, the feudal system operated in Palestine during the Crusades, and also in Japan, where samurai gave military service to their overlords in return for land.

Lords and vassals

In the European feudal system, the only person who actually owned land was the king. When the king granted land to a baron, the baron knelt and pledged to be the king's vassal (servant). Lesser lords swore a similar oath to the barons and became their vassals, and peasants swore allegiance to the lords. Bishops were also the king's vassals, and held nearly as much power as the barons.



Feudal counsel

Kings and barons often asked for advice, or counsel, from their vassals when making any important decisions. This 14th-century French manuscript shows Philip VI of France judging Robert of Valois, helped by the bishops on his right hand and the barons on his left.



Feudal contract

The people owed their loyalty to the monarch. This "contract" meant that Philip VI could – and did – tax his subjects heavily to finance the Hundred Years War.



How feudalism began

The great emperor Charlemagne insisted that all his nobles swear loyalty to him. This bond between lord and warrior began the feudal system. Over the next two centuries, feudalism spread through France, Germany, northern Italy, the Slav countries, and finally the British Isles and Sicily.

Mounted warriors

Warriors riding horses to war became more common after 950. These warriors were the first knights. They had great prestige, and became an important part of the feudal system.



Derisive image of king with cat, not crown, on his head

King

Although the king owned the land, he could rarely afford to keep an army. He was often in conflict with the barons, on whom he relied for his warriors.



Barons

The most powerful of all the nobles, the barons got their lands directly from the king. Because they provided the royal army, they had great power and prestige.



Local lords

Local knights got their land (or manor) from the barons. In return, they fought for the barons when needed. As time went on, local lords often paid a tax called scutage (shield money) instead of fighting, and the king used this money to hire professional soldiers. In peacetime, they farmed and kept order.



Peasants

The peasants, at the bottom of feudal society, got their plots of land from the local lord of the manor. He allowed them to farm this land; in return, they paid rent in produce and money. The peasants also contributed several days' labour on "public" projects such as road- and bridge-building.

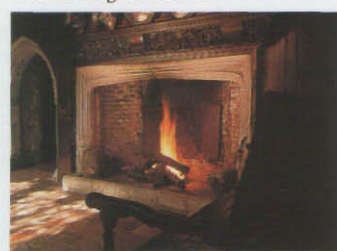


Ightham Mote, England

The manor house

Every manor house had a hall. This acted as the dining and living room for the family, and also a general reception room where the peasants paid their rent. The kitchen was at one end of the hall, beside a pantry and buttery (store room for drinks). Buildings in the courtyard outside included workshops and cattle-sheds. The whole complex was often surrounded by a moat for protection.

The Hall, Ightham Mote



Domesday Book

For the feudal system to work well, the ruler needed detailed information about the land and who lived on it. William of Normandy, who introduced feudalism to Britain, had a complete record made of all land ownership in England in 1085–86. This became known as the Domesday Book.



The book is the most complete record of land-holding in medieval Europe.

William I

The illegitimate son of Duke Robert I of Normandy, William (c.1028–1087) conquered England in 1066. He introduced the feudal system to the island, and replaced Saxon nobles with Norman lords.



FIND OUT MORE

CHARLEMAGNE

HUNDRED YEARS WAR

KNIGHTS AND HERALDRY

MEDIEVAL EUROPE

NORMANS

SAMURAI AND SHOGUNS